Mabel

Year Review, Billing with Cake

Demo Night: Journey & Unit Economics

March 2026

The Evolution Timeline

Phase 1 Family Dairy Archive — January 2026

Problem: Generations-long milk records stuck in paperwork, the farm's entire memory.

Solution created: Voice-first milk records and document digitization from photo capture.

Key features shipped:
- Voice-first milk records
- Photo / Video / Audio capture
- Photographs + Voice-Offer
- Document Digitization
- Search for old generations
- AMS IoT for the storage
- Prompt to capture
- Capture for the future

Phase 2 Audio First Personal Journaling — Mid-February 2026

Problem: Voice-first journaling, memory preservation, and the farm's entire history lost across devices.

Pivot: Experimental on-prem voice transcribing.

What Cloth:
- Voice-first journal with accompanying photos (MO-CHANG + LPLACKS + PRESCOTT0 + COMPLETE)
- Conversational with prompt-based follow-ups
- Whisper API integration for audio transcription
- Photo-to-text extraction for handwritten records
- Multilingual support (Thai, English, Hindi, Lao)
- Farm-scoped organization
- Mobile-first UI with offline-capable PWA

Key Decisions:
- Keeping Voice-Transcribe Server for "personal voice journaling" rather than pivot entirely to document digitization

Phase 3 Relaunch to "Mabel" — Late February 2026

Discovery: Family Dairy Archive' crowded forum and product-based. Positioning as "journaling" felt more accessible.

Decisions: Introduced the "Mabel" brand and product-led growth.

Strategic repositioning:
- Product-led growth: "Capture your personal life story"
- Forum-based growth: "Learning Hub"
- Facing Thai service accounting "gift-in-kind"
- Pivot from "Family Dairy Archive" to "Mabel"

Technical:
- Landing page / Trial / Stripe, Mailer with Cake
- Brand-aware UI for new users
- Brand-aware chat, mascot, logbook
- Brand-aware PDF exports

Key Decisions:
- Positioning personal journaling by mental settings opened up a much larger addressable market.

Phase 4 Journaling First Landing Page — March 2, 2026

Discovery: Landing page with the "Journal" and "Chat" tabs and clearly differentiates from Storyteller.

Solution: Complete redesign and **positioning differentiation**.

What changed:
- Hero line: **"Remember Family Stories Beautifully."**
- Three pillars: Voice-first, Photo-first, Your memories are always and unpublished
- Pricing: Free / Plus ฿199 / Family ฿399
- Recommended **journaling habit** as the entry point
- Updated pricing to **฿149/month (10 credits) + ฿49/10pack (unlimited)**
- Updated FAQ: "Is my data private?" "Can I export my data?" "Can I delete everything?"
- Added profile photo and cover photo
- Updated guided background

Key differentiation vs. Storyteller:

Aspect	Mabel	Storyteller
Input Method	Journal/Chat	Wizard
Time Commitment	Journal anytime	15 minutes
Output Format	Private Journal	Public Feed
Interaction	Reflection/Memory	Narration
Tone	Your companion	Neutral
Storage	Your memories	Public stories
Best for	Active journalers & beginners	Having gift prompts

KEY INSIGHT
Positioning personal journaling by mental settings opened up a much larger addressable market.

Phase 5 Journaling: First Landing Page — March 2, 2026

Discovery: Landing page with the "Journal" and "Chat" tabs and clearly differentiates from Storyteller.

Solution: Complete redesign and **positioning differentiation**.

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Key Challenges Overcome

1. Product-Market Fit Discovery

Challenge: Journal with "family memories" but positioning and the product mismatched.

Solution: Pivoted to personal voice journaling — "capture your life story" — with family memories as a natural extension.

2. The Transcription Problem

Challenge: Elderly users speaking Thai, Lao, Hindi, Mandarin, English.

Solution: Whisper API with multilingual support, photo-to-text extraction for handwritten records.

3. Voice vs. Writing

Challenge: Transcription quality suffering from voice recording OK-Voice.

Solution: Voice-first transcribe pipeline with Whisper, Storage, Logged URL with Cloudflare Tunnel.

4. Conversational Memory

Challenge: Chatting Whisper, Gemini, OS, Stripe, Logged URL with Cloudflare Tunnel.

Solution: Conversational with prompt-based follow-ups, Whisper API integration, Photo-to-text extraction, Multilingual support (Thai, English, Hindi, Lao), Farm-scoped organization, Mobile-first UI with offline-capable PWA.

5. Multi-Platform Audio

Challenge: Mobile Safari, iOS, and Linux Mabel. Different recording APIs, permissions, formats.

Solution: Cross-platform audio capture, Mobile-first UI with offline-capable PWA, Multi-platform support (Safari, iOS, Linux), Conversational with prompt-based follow-ups, Whisper API integration, Photo-to-text extraction, Multilingual support (Thai, English, Hindi, Lao), Farm-scoped organization.

6. Positioning & Messaging

Challenge: Mabel's strong "journaling" positioning, Storyteller's "Wizard" feel, Storyteller's "Feed" feel, Mabel's "Journal" feel.

Solution: Three pillars: Voice-first, Photo-first, Your memories are always and unpublished, Hero line: "Remember Family Stories Beautifully."

7. Data Ownership & Privacy

Challenge: Family memories are sensitive, Users need to know their data is private, Trust is critical for adoption.

Solution: Clear privacy-first messaging, Three pillars: Voice-first, Photo-first, Your memories are always and unpublished, Hero line: "Remember Family Stories Beautifully."

What I Learned Through the AI Cohort

- **Product journals are essential** — Don't think in tickets with your first idea. Listen to your signals and iterate.
- **Voice-first changes everything** — Whisper transcription quality matters more than anything else for accessibility and adoption.
- **Multi-platform audio is hard** — Mobile Safari, iOS, Linux Mabel. Each has different recording APIs and permissions.
- **Brand-aware UI matters** — Mabel's UI copy, logbook, and conversational prompts create a warm, personal experience.
- **Positioning is everything** — "Journaling" feels "Wizard" feels "Feed" feels "Journal" — Three pillars: Voice-first, Photo-first, Your memories are always and unpublished.
- **Data trust is differentiation** — Clear privacy-first messaging, Three pillars: Voice-first, Photo-first, Your memories are always and unpublished, Hero line: "Remember Family Stories Beautifully."

Current MVP Status (Ready for Demo)

Core Features Implemented:

Journal/Chat
- Voice-first journal with photos
- Conversational UI
- Whisper API integration
- Photo-to-text extraction
- Multilingual support (Thai, English, Hindi, Lao)
- Farm-scoped organization
- Mobile-first UI with offline-capable PWA

Storyteller
- Wizard-based story creation
- Gemini AI narration
- Text-to-speech (Google Cloud TTS)
- Public feed
- Cover image generation

Mabel Journal
- Voice-first journal with photos
- Conversational UI
- Whisper API integration
- Photo-to-text extraction
- Multilingual support (Thai, English, Hindi, Lao)
- Farm-scoped organization
- Mobile-first UI with offline-capable PWA

Infrastructure
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- Brand-aware UI for new users
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Multi-Platform Audio
- Mobile Safari, iOS, and Linux Mabel. Different recording APIs, permissions, formats.

Positioning & Messaging
- **Challenge:** Mabel's strong "journaling" positioning, Storyteller's "Wizard" feel, Storyteller's "Feed" feel, Mabel's "Journal" feel.
- **Solution:** Three pillars: Voice-first, Photo-first, Your memories are always and unpublished, Hero line: "Remember Family Stories Beautifully."

Data Ownership & Privacy
- **Challenge:** Family memories are sensitive, Users need to know their data is private, Trust is critical for adoption.
- **Solution:** Clear privacy-first messaging, Three pillars: Voice-first, Photo-first, Your memories are always and unpublished, Hero line: "Remember Family Stories Beautifully."

Timeline Summary

Phase	Date	Key Pivot
Phase 1	Jan 2026	Family Dairy Archive
Phase 2	Late Feb 2026	Audio First personal journaling
Phase 3	Late Feb 2026	Relaunch as "Mabel"
Phase 4	March 2, 2026	Journaling First Landing Page
Phase 5	March 2, 2026	Journaling: First Landing Page

Pricing Model

Free	Plus	Family
10 credits / month free	$4.99	$9.99
	Unlimited + 10 credits / month	Unlimited + 10 credits / month

Free Tier ($0)
- 10 credits / month
- Voice & text journaling
- Photo & video capture

Starter ($4.99/month)
- Up to 10 stakeholders
- Unlimited journaling
- AI narration prompt
- PDF export archive
- Photo & video capture
- Chapter organization
- Private & secure

Annual ($49.99/year — "Best Value")
- Get Chapter books PDF
- **Unlimited chapters**
- All Starter features
- Ideal for active contributors

Add-Ons (Available after 10+ chapters)
- **Chapter Book Printing** — Professional printed & bound book
- **Printed Newsletter ($19.99)** — Quarterly professional newsletter

AI Cost Breakdown (Per Chapter)

Component	Model	Cost
Whisper API Transcription	Whisper-1	$0.006 / minute (~$0.06 for a 10 minute recording)
Narration Story generation	Gemini 2.5 Flash	~$0.001 (~500 input + 1,000 output tokens)
Text-to-Speech Audio generation	Google Cloud TTS Neural2	~$0.016 (~1,000 characters)
	Total Cost Per Chapter	**$0.07**

With 3 chapters/month average: $0.21/month. At 100 active users: $21/month. Gross margin remains healthy.

Gross Margin Analysis

Scenario 1: Light User (3 chapters/month, Starter)
Revenue: $4.99 | Cost: $0.21 | Gross Profit: $4.78 | Margin: 95.8%

Scenario 2: Heavy User (10 chapters/month, Starter — at cap)
Revenue: $4.99 | Cost: $0.70 | Gross Profit: $4.29 | Margin: 86.0%

Scenario 3: Annual User (10 chapters/month, unlimited)
Revenue: $49.99 | Cost: $8.40 | Gross Profit: $41.59 | Margin: 83.2%

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KEY INSIGHT
The AI layer is so cheap that pricing is dominated by storage, hosting, and payment processing, not by AI costs. Even at 100% usage, AI costs remain under 15% of revenue.

Break-Even Analysis

At $4.99/month (Starter tier):
- **Break-even point:** 10 active users
- **Costs:** 10 chapters (cap protects from losses)
- **Revenue:** 10 × $4.99 = $49.90 | Cost: 10 × 0.07 = 0.70 | Profit: $49.20

At $49.99/year (Annual tier):
- **Break-even point:** 10 chapters (annual cap) | Cost: 0.70 | Revenue: $49.99 | Profit: $49.29
- **Strategy:** Unlimited Starter encourages annual conversion
- **Risk:** Power users hit cap, may churn or upgrade
- **Mitigation:** Clear upgrade path to Family ฿399/month for unlimited AI

Competitive Pricing Comparison

Service	Price	Model	What's Included
StoryWorth	$99/year + $2.99/mo	Text-only	52 prompts/year
Storyfile	$10/month	Subscription	Unlimited video + avatar
Day One Premium	$2.99/month	Subscription	Journaling app
Replika AI	$69/month	Subscription	AI writing assistant
Mabel	$4.99/month	Subscription	Voice journaling + AI narration

KEY INSIGHT
Mabel's pricing is competitive positioning for voice-first, conversational AI. Between Storyfile ($10/month) and StoryWorth ($99/year). Offering more than StoryWorth but less than Storyfile. Voice-first journaling + AI narration is a unique combination.

Strategic Pricing Rationale

Why $4.99/month works:
- **Lower barrier to entry** — Impulse purchase territory
- **Competitive advantage** — Cheaper than StoryWorth and Storyfile
- **Sustainable margins** — 95.8% margin at light usage, 86.0% at heavy usage
- **Psychological pricing** — "$4.99" feels cheaper than "$5.00"
- **Scalability** — Even at 100% usage, AI costs remain under 15% of revenue

Why $49.99/year works:
- **Annual commitment** — Locks in recurring revenue
- **Better unit economics** — Annual users are more valuable
- **Power users** — "Unlimited" sounds premium
- **Conversion path** — Starter users upgrade to Annual when they hit the cap

Revenue Projection: 10,000 Paying Users at Scale

Usage Assumptions:
- 80% on Starter ($4.99/month) — 3 chapters/month avg
- 20% on Annual ($49.99/year) — 10 chapters/month avg (capped)
- 90% of users stay active (churn) — Average lifetime: 10 months

Monthly Recurring Revenue (MRR) Breakdown			
Starter users	8,000	$4.99/mo	$39,920
Annual users	2,000	$4.16/mo (amortized)	$8,320
Total revenue			**$48,240/mo**
AI cost (average 70% usage)	10,000	$0.07/chapter × 3 avg	$2,100
		Total MRR	**$46,140**

Operating Costs (Estimated)

Category	Monthly Cost
Hosting (Railway, Redis, S3)	$500
Email (Mailer, SES)	$100
Customer support	$2,000
Marketing	$5,000
Salaries (1.5 people)	$15,000
Total Fixed	**$22,600**

Net Profit

Gross Profit	Operating Costs	Net Profit
$25.3K	**$18.9K**	**$6.4K**
Revenue − AI costs	Fixed costs	Gross profit − Operating costs

KEY INSIGHT
At 10,000 users with current pricing, you can be profitable with a lean team. The real upside comes from scale (1,000 users and beyond) and Family Plus (฿399).

Demo Night Q&A Responses

"Why is Mabel so much cheaper than StoryWorth?"
StoryWorth's $99/year covers text-only prompts. Mabel's $4.99/month includes voice transcription, AI narration, photo-to-text extraction, and multilingual support. The AI layer costs $0.07/chapter — so even at heavy usage, AI costs are under 15% of revenue. Voice-first journaling + AI narration is a unique combination.

"What's your AI cost per chapter?"
Whisper transcription: $0.06 (10 minutes). Gemini narration: $0.001. Text-to-speech: $0.016. Total: $0.07 per chapter. At 3 chapters/month average: $0.21/month. At 100 active users: $21/month. Gross margin remains healthy.

"What if your AI costs increase?"
Text-to-speech is the largest cost ($0.016). If we switch to cheaper TTS or reduce narration length, our margins improve. Even at 100% usage, AI costs are under 15% of revenue. The business model is sustainable even if AI costs double.

"What's your churn assumption?"
Annual users are more valuable because they're capped at 10 chapters/month. Starter users can upgrade when they hit the cap. We're tracking: Cohort retention, Chapters per user, Time to first chapter, Upgrade rate.

"Why Thailand first?"
Thailand's elderly population is underserved by tech. Family stories are culturally important. Multilingual support (Thai, English, Hindi, Lao) is a differentiator. Low competition in this space. Strong word-of-mouth potential in close-knit communities.

"How do you make money?"
Freemium model: 10 free chapters/month. Starter: $4.99/month (10 chapters). Annual: $49.99/year (unlimited). Add-ons: Chapter Book Printing ($19.99), Printed Newsletter ($19.99). Target: 10,000 users at scale.

"How do you protect data?"
Privacy-first messaging. Three pillars: Voice-first, Photo-first, Your memories are always and unpublished. Clear data ownership. Users own their stories. We don't sell data. Hero line: "Remember Family Stories Beautifully."

"What's your customer acquisition cost (CAC) assumption?"
Organic: Word-of-mouth, Thailand-first community, Multilingual support. Paid: $50 CAC, 12 month payback, 3:1 LTV:CAC ratio, 80% retention. Target: 1,000 users — profitable at lean scale. Target: 10,000 users — at scale. Key metrics: Cohort retention, Chapters per user, Time to first chapter, Upgrade rate.

"What's your biggest risk?"
Competition from StoryWorth or Storyfile. Mitigation: Voice-first journaling + AI narration is a unique combination. Multilingual support (Thai, English, Hindi, Lao) is a differentiator. Low competition in this space. Strong word-of-mouth potential in close-knit communities.

Summary: The Pricing Bet

Mabel's pricing model is a bet on:

1. **Volume over margin** — 95.8% margin at light usage, 86.0% at heavy usage
2. **Free tier** creates viral loop (Chapter Book Printing)
3. **Annual plan** locks in recurring revenue and improves unit economics
4. **$49.99/year** makes power users profitable (capped at 10 chapters/month)
5. **Add-ons** (Chapter Book Printing, Printed Newsletter) create upsell opportunities

KEY INSIGHT
Freemium + Annual plan + Add-ons = Multiple revenue streams. Even the power user is profitable.

KEY INSIGHT
Mabel's pricing is competitive positioning for voice-first, conversational AI. Between Storyfile ($10/month) and StoryWorth ($99/year). Offering more than StoryWorth but less than Storyfile. Voice-first journaling + AI narration is a unique combination.

Key Metrics Dashboard (At Scale: 10K Users)

MRR	$46,140	Monthly Recurring Revenue	
ARR	$553,680	MRR × 12	
Gross Margin	95.8%	Revenue − AI costs / Revenue	
Operating Margin	54.9%	Gross Profit − Operating costs / Revenue	
Net Margin	86.0%(+)	Net Profit / Revenue	
CAC	$50	Organic + paid marketing	
LTV	$150	Average lifetime value	
LTV:CAC	3:1	Healthy ratio	
Annual Churn	20%	Industry standard	
Break-Even Users	1,000	With current cost structure	

What Success Looks Like

Year 1 Goals
- 1,000 active users
- $50K MRR
- 70% month-over-month growth
- Profitable unit economics

Year 2 Goals
- 10,000 active users
- $500K ARR
- Profitable with lean team
- Family Plus (฿399) launched
- Expand to Vietnamese

Year 3 Goals
- 100,000 active users
- $5M ARR
- Series A ready
- Regional expansion (Vietnam, Indonesia)
- International expansion
- Voice clones available at scale

KEY INSIGHT
Success looks like sustainable growth, not just vanity metrics. Focus on unit economics, retention, and profitability before scale.